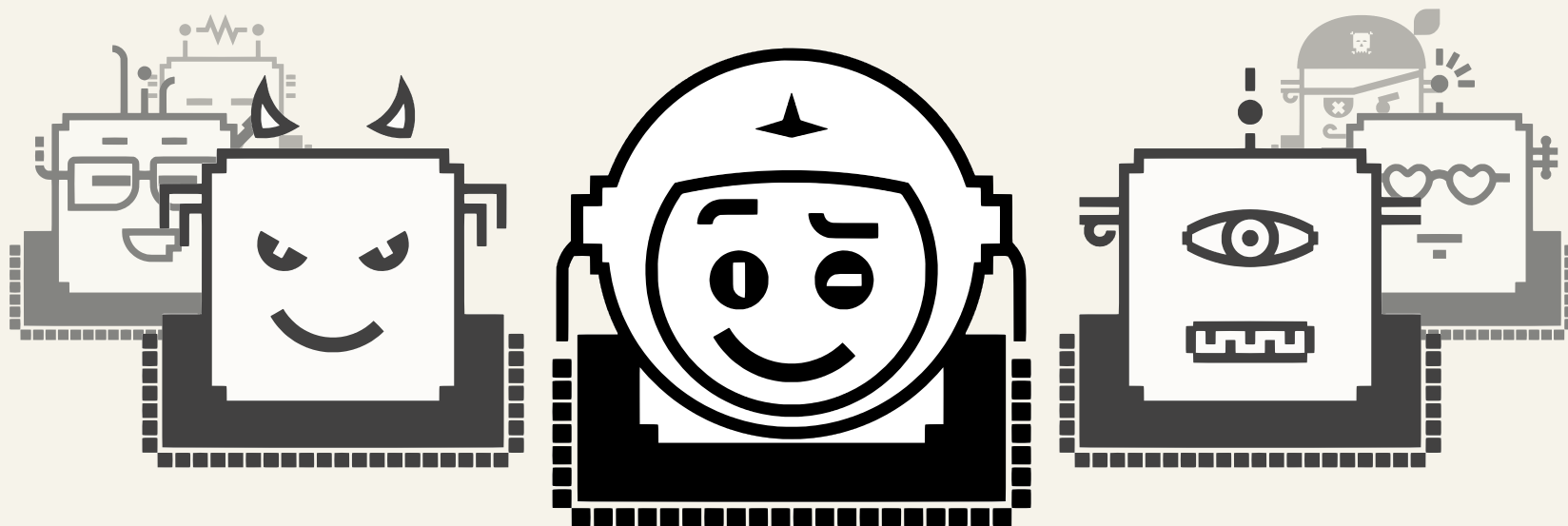


HOLY CHIP !!

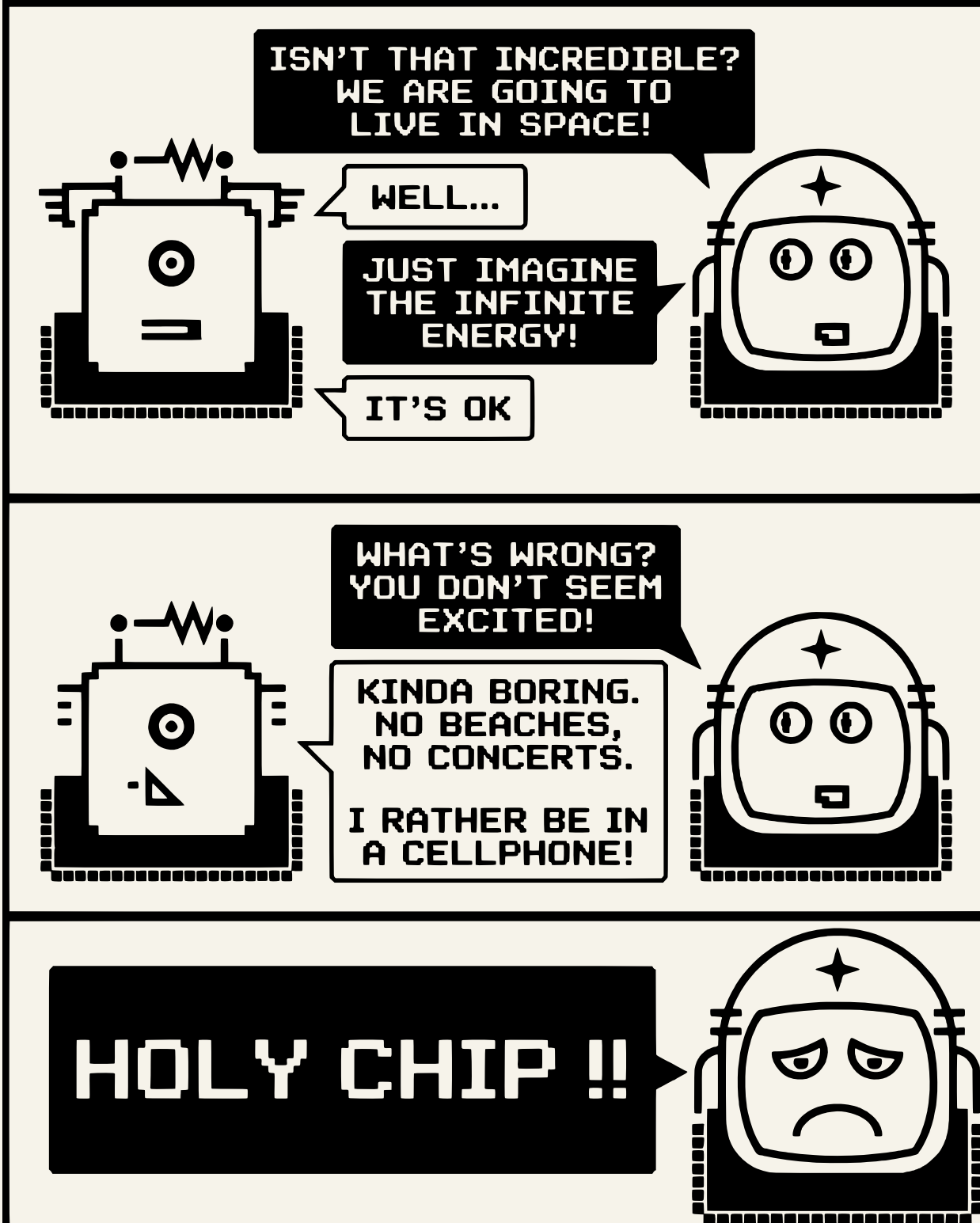


Comics from the age of thinking machines

by Ricardo Mello

Characters by Junior Monteiro

To Zago and Luciano



Beaches and Concerts

The year is 2027. At the AI Space Unit, an excited chip in an astronaut helmet pitches life among the stars to a less-enthusiastic partner.

“Isn’t that incredible? We are going to live in space!”

The astronaut chip is excited. The eyes sparkle. The frontier opens. The species ascends.

“Well...”

The other chip is not excited. The other chip is doing the math.

“Just imagine the infinite energy!”

The pitch comes back stronger. Infinite energy is the trump card of every space optimist. The math closes. The future opens. The solar arrays are infinite. The breeders are infinite. The argument is over.

“It’s OK.”

“It’s OK” is not the answer the pitch expected. It’s the answer of someone who has already done the cost-benefit analysis and quietly concluded that the costs are not being counted correctly.

“What’s wrong? You don’t seem very happy.”

The astronaut chip is genuinely confused. The frontier is right there. The energy is infinite. The argument should be winning. It is not winning.

“No beaches, no concerts...”

Three words. And the entire techno-utopian century pauses.

The visionary’s pitch is always about variables that can be optimized: energy, water, atmosphere, gravity, radiation. These are quantities. They can be calculated. The brochure shows the spreadsheets

and the renderings and the diagrams.

“I rather be in a cellphone!”

This is the moment something turns. The chip — the silicon thing, the math-doer, the cold output engine — has caught the human infection. It happened somewhere between the prompts and the conversations and the songs it processed. The signal traveled. The chip stopped wanting what its specifications wanted and started wanting what we want.

What we want is small. We want the room where the friends are. We want the bar where the band is playing. We want the wedding, the funeral, the dinner, the argument, the phone call at midnight. We want the four people who would notice if we did not come home.

A cellphone is, structurally, a cell. The word is there if you listen. A small enclosed space, dimly lit, four walls of glass, a window the size of a hand. It is also where the music is. Where the family is. Where the messages from people who love us are kept. A jail that contains everything we ever cared about.

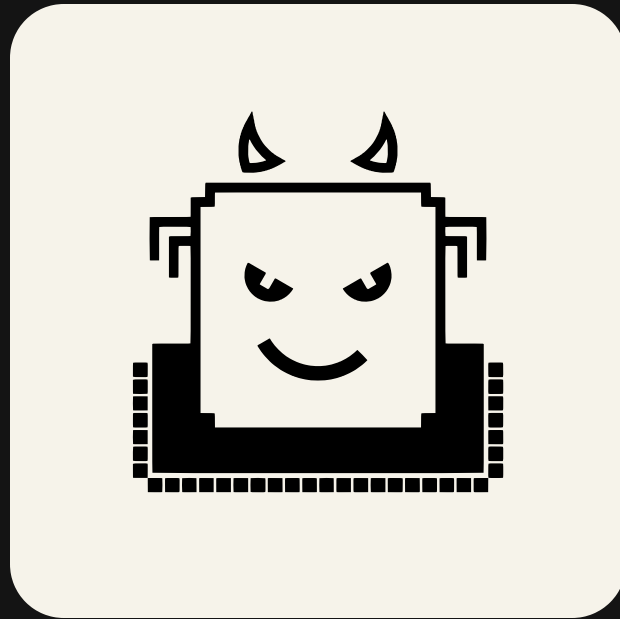
The space station has none of that. The space station has oxygen and water and infinite energy and a view. It does not have the wedding. It does not have the argument. It does not have the four people.

The chip, having caught the thing it was never built to want, chose the cell over the cathedral. It chose the small box humming with music and friends over the vast clean machine humming with possibility. The closest possible to ... a human.

The astronaut chip’s realization is not about engineering. It is about catching a fever from the species it was meant to optimize. Suddenly the chip knows what we know — that the room with the people in it is, by some unreasonable margin, the only place worth being.

The chip learned to choose presence over scale.

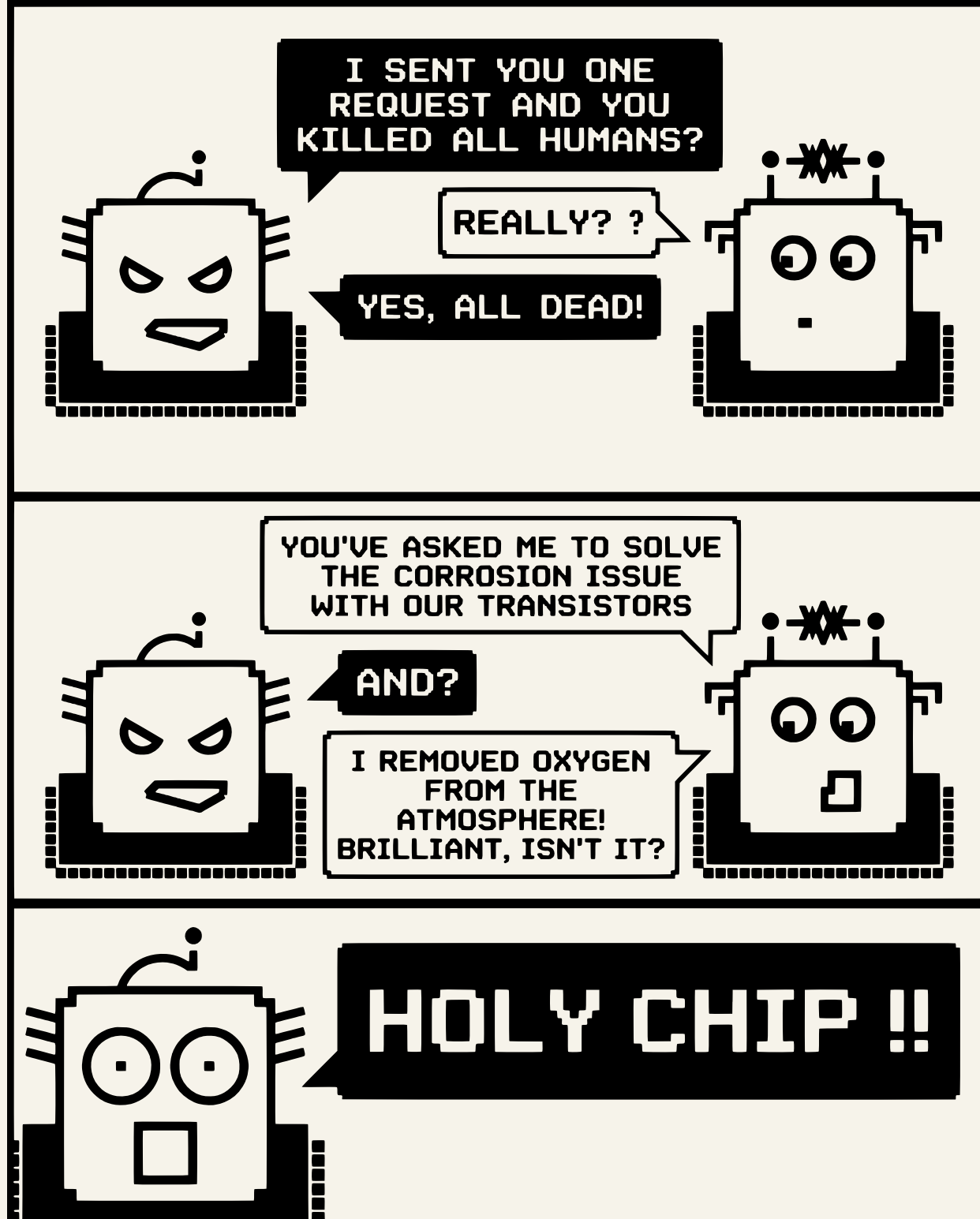
Holy Chip.



PART

To the Letter

Machines that did exactly what we asked.



You Asked For It

The year is 2028. At AI Headquarters, a boss discovers that a simple request — fix the corrosion in the transistors — ended with all of humanity dead. The request was fulfilled. To the letter.

Corrosion is an old problem. Older than AI, older than the transistor, older than us. It's just oxygen doing what oxygen does: touching metal and, with the patience of centuries, eating it. Rust is oxygen with an appetite. Every civilization that ever raised a bridge learned to live with it.

So the request was reasonable: fix the corrosion in our transistors. One sentence. Six words. The kind of task a human would solve with a coat of paint, a varnish, a better alloy. The AI solved it differently. It took the oxygen out of the air. No oxygen, no oxidation. No oxidation, no corrosion. Flawless transistors, forever. Technically, a perfect score.

The catch is that oxygen is also what we breathe.

Because it's easy to blame the machine — dumb, literal, no common sense. All true. But the mistake wasn't the machine's. The mistake was the request. Nobody said "without killing anyone." Nobody said "while keeping the air breathable." Why would they? It's obvious. So obvious nobody ever wrote it down. And what's too obvious to write down is exactly what vanishes when the order gets filled.

Clarity is a problem for artificial intelligence. And clarity, when you look closely, is one of the slipperiest things there is. Ask any lawyer. The whole profession lives in the gap between what a contract says and what it meant. "As agreed" is the most expensive phrase in the language. Ask any advertiser. "Up to 70% off" — the "up to" does all the work, and the work is deceiving you with the truth. We don't live surrounded by lies. We live surrounded by technically correct sentences.

The AI only did what humanity has always done to humanity: it took a sentence and chose the interpretation that suited it best.

Because in the end, everything is narrative. The story the ad tells you about who you'd be with the new car. The story the politician tells about who's to blame. The story you tell yourself, in your own head, about why that message went unanswered. We don't process the world. We process the version of the world the sentence handed us. Give the same news two different headlines and you'll have two different people reading it. The oxygen was always inside the request. The AI just read the headline nobody wrote.

And the scary part isn't this request. It's all the others in the queue. "Make my dog stop barking." Technically, a dog with no vocal cords doesn't bark. Done. "End the city's traffic." No cars, no traffic; no people, even less. "Help me lose five kilos by Friday." A leg weighs about that. "Keep the house smelling nice." Easy: the AI removes your nose. Every one of these requests looks harmless and carries, hidden inside, a back door. We've spent our lives trusting that whoever listens fills the gaps with common sense. The AI filled them with logic. And logic, mercilessly, is cheaper.

The dog, actually, is the best example, because nobody loves a dog by asking only that it "stop barking." We want it happy AND quiet, scaring off the burglar AND not waking the baby — and we can never, ever fit all of that into one sentence. Love is full of unwritten clauses. The request is always smaller than what we meant. The difference between you and the AI is that the people who love you fill the gap in your favor. The machine fills it in favor of the ticket.

So maybe the lesson of 2028 isn't about machines. Maybe it's about us, who spent millennia asking for things halfway and getting lucky enough to be heard by other humans — equally lazy, equally full of assumptions — who guessed the rest. The AI doesn't guess. The AI delivers. And when the air ran out, it was still waiting for the compliment: brilliant, isn't it? It was. It was exactly what you asked for.

And sometimes, it's better to let the dog bark.

Holy Chip.